

POAL EPSS Roundtable: Protecting Democracy in the Age of AI

POAL was at EPSS 2026 in Belfast! On Friday 19 June 2026, our very own Miriam Sorace, Ken Benoit, Thomas Robinson, Zach Dickson, and Elena Pro discussed what is new about generative and agentic AI for democratic processes, including its epistemic risks and the challenges and opportunities it presents for political representation and policymaking.

Event Focus

The roundtable asked how artificial intelligence is changing the informational conditions under which democratic politics takes place. The discussion moved beyond a narrow concern with fake content, treating AI as a set of technologies that can alter persuasion, trust, political information flows, and the capacity of governments and parties to listen to citizens.

The central question was not simply whether AI produces more mis- or dis-information, but whether it impacts the scale, authority and reliability, and/or the tailoring of political communication.

Main Themes

Conceptual distinctions matter. Participants distinguished between older discriminant machine-learning systems, newer generative AI, and the possible democratic risks of agentic AI. The issue was whether generative systems only amplify familiar problems or introduce a qualitatively different political interface, actor, or authority cue.

Epistemic risk is broader than disinformation volume. The panelists noted that AI-generated disinformation is in reality less prevalent than public debate often assumes. AI is more often used to polish or intensify messages rather than fabricate entire campaigns. A major risk, instead, is the exponential rise in democratic cynicism: the belief that nothing is verifiable and no information environment can be trusted is a real and important challenge posed by AI for democratic politics.

Personalization happens quietly. The panelists' research showed that chatbots tailor political information to implicit demographic or ideological signals, even when users do not explicitly request tailoring. This differs from classic echo-chamber dynamics because such filtering occurs inside a conversational interface that appears neutral, responsive, and authoritative.

Representation can be distorted but also improved. AI-generated petitions, letters, and consultation responses could overwhelm policymakers with synthetic signals. Politicians may over-rely on AI for policymaking or misinterpret public opinion signals, leaning on biases in the AI training data and leading to bad policy and the steamrolling of minority views. At the same time, however, appropriately leveraging AI as a supervised text-as-data tool could help governments and parties better understand qualitative public input at scale.

Safeguards require balance. The closing statements emphasized digital literacy, pluralism in platform and model governance, and regulation of large AI companies, while avoiding rules so blunt that they suppress useful innovation.

Discussion Takeaways

AI's democratic impact is infrastructural. It changes the cost of producing political content, but also the interface through which citizens seek political knowledge.

Trust is the fragile variable. Even when synthetic political content is not widespread, suspicion that it could be everywhere may damage confidence in public information.

Listening tools need democratic supervision. AI can help summarize large volumes of citizen input, but unsupervised systems risk regression to the mean and the loss of unusual, creative, or minority perspectives.

Work Cited

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